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COVER STORY

As the Boxer Rebellion Stole Headlines from His Wild West, Buffalo Bill Put the Clash into His Show

Thus was the stage set for the “Western Easterners” to man a wall and defend their position against U.

David McCormick · HistoryNet

Fresh from robbing the Deadwood Stagecoach, the Sioux performers of Buffalo Bill’s Wild West changed into loose-fitting Chinese garb and attached long single braids to the backs of their heads, mimicking the clothing and hairstyle of the Boxers then rebelling halfway around the world. Thus was the stage set for the “Western Easterners” to man a wall and defend their position against U. S. Army re-enactors in a scene played out in Cody’s “Rescue at Peking.”

Pittsburgh was the host city this day in late May 1901, and the big-city crowd did not disappoint. As the action unfolded, spectators stomped their feet so hard as to send vibrations through the grandstand. During the climactic scene, as the Army re-enactors scaled the artificial wall, the jingoistic roar from audience members swelled to ear-throbbing intensity, and they surged over the railings to join performers on the arena floor.

The drama depicted actual events of the ongoing 1899–1901 Boxer Rebellion. Emerging as a violent response to increasing foreign incursion into China, the Boxers (nicknamed for their martial arts skills, though officially known as the Society of Righteous and Harmonious Fists) sought to eradicate all signs of modern progress (railroads, telegraph lines, etc.) and called for the liquidation of foreigners, particularly Christian missionaries (and their Chinese converts).

On June 20, 1900, the Boxers besieged foreign embassies in the Legation Quarter of Peking (present-day Beijing), trapping within its walls nearly 500 foreign civilians, 400 military personnel and 3,000 Chinese Christians. Fifty-five days into the siege eight nations, including the United States, sent some 20,000 soldiers to relieve the siege. In battle that August 14 and 15 they defeated the Boxers and then divided the capital city into occupation zones, sending occasional punitive forays into the countryside. Not until Sept. 7, 1901, did representatives of the allied nations and

China’s Qing empire sign the Boxer Protocol, officially ending the rebellion.

Ever the savvy showman, Cody was quick to draw a correlation between the Boxers and American Indians. As the rebels had resisted foreign incursion, he reasoned, so Plains Indians had resisted the westward tide of Anglo settlement, cutting telegraph lines, attacking railroad crews and battling U. S. soldiers. Fueled by superstitious ideology, the Boxers believed they could induce spirits to enter their bodies and render them invulnerable to bullets, much like Plains Indian adherents of the “Ghost Dance” movement believed their ceremonial shirts would protect them. The latter movement ended in tragedy on Dec. 29, 1890, with the battle turned massacre at Wounded Knee, S. D., all but ending the American Indian wars.

Buffalo Bill was a stickler for the authentic, wherever possible employing real soldiers, cowboys and Indians performing with real weapons. But as he had no access to real Boxers, the duty fell to those Sioux already in Cody’s employ. They were perfect for the role, one New York Sun reporter quipped, as they were “used to dying” in each show. “They die in the cowboy battles about the emigrant wagon, and they die again in the chase of the Deadwood coach,” he wrote. “They made no objection to...dying the death of Boxers this year.” A New York Evening Sun reporter noted, tongue in cheek, “Some of them seemed a little ill at ease in

their Chinese makeup, but they kept themselves entirely in the landscape, positively refused to scalp a single member of the allied forces and never even indulged in so much as the ghost of a war whoop.”

American Indians had long featured in promotions for the Wild West, which urged potential ticket buyers to come see the “horde of warpainted Arapaho, Cheyenne and Sioux Indians” (though after convincing the infamous Hunkpapa Lakota leader Sitting Bull to tour with him in 1885, Cody had hired only Sioux from the Pine Ridge Agency). Why did Plains Indians who had violently resisted “foreign incursion” agree to perform in the Wild West shows? For starters, those working for Buffalo Bill earned a decent wage, while employment prospects on and around the reservations were limited. In addition, room, board and travel were free. Finally, performers’ immediate families were welcome to join them on tour.

, all but ending the American Indian wars.

David McCormick

In the actual 1899-1901 Boxer Rebellion namesake Chinese insurgents (pictured above in U. S. captivity) besieged the foreign embassies in Peking (present-day Beijing). In Buffalo Bill’s version of events cowboys costumed as American soldiers retook the city walls from Sioux performers clad in Chinese silks and pin-on braids.

In the fall of 1900, drawn like so many Americans by the dramatic events in China, Cody proposed to his theatrical manager, Nate Salsbury, that they incorporate a reenactment of the allied victory over the Boxers in the forthcoming season of the Wild West. The pair put their heads together and came up with “The Rescue at Peking.”

On April 2, 1901, opening night, they debuted the Chinese-themed spectacle at New York’s Madison Square Garden. After a fortnight’s run Cody took the show on the road, and by the time the season wrapped in late October the troupe had performed in arenas from upstate New York to the South and across much of the Midwest. In 1902, with few changes to the program, Cody and company performed for audiences in the Western half of the country.

The twice-daily shows were an enormous draw, attracting on average some 20,000 to 30,000 patrons, not counting those turned away at the gate. The audience often exceeded the population of the host cities, as people from surrounding areas packed the stands. The June 4 edition of Pennsylvania’s Reading Herald reported that crowds began to gather in the early morning, by showtime transforming into a “great huddled mass.”

As the battle between the Boxers and the soldiers marked the grand finale of each performance, Cody and Salsbury spared no expense. “It was indeed an enormous and costly undertaking,” author John R. Haddad writes, “requiring 100

horses, large amounts of gunpowder and explosives, the latest in cannons and firearms, and of course the massive wall of Peking that loomed majestically over one end of the arena.” The cast alone, including the braided Sioux “Boxers,” numbered 500.

The performance lacked for nothing. Whether it was authentically cast or accurate in every detail was beside the point. Cody and company were, above all else, entertainers, and whether clad in Western buckskins or Chinese silks, they seldom disappointed the huddled masses.

This article originally appeared in the Spring 2024 issue of Wild West magazine.

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FRONT PAGE

Episode 239: Blank Pages

Nate DiMeo · The Memory Palace

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The Lady With the Golden Stockings from the Sun Ra Arkestra The Sage from the Chico Hamilton Quintet Falling in Love with a New York Pigeon by Birb Bocherini's fourth quintet as performed by the Ensemble of St. Martin of the Fields From a Dream by Oregon Jaybird from the great Charlie Parr Pool of Love by Les Baxter And House Tuner Theme from Will Bates' gorgeous score to The Sound of Silence.

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FEATURES

An SAS Rescue Mission Mission Gone Wrong

Gavin Mortimer · HistoryNet

Norman Crockatt is not a well-known name, but the British intelligence officer was responsible for one of the most controversial decisions of World War II.

When the War Office in London created Military Intelligence Section 9 (MI9) on December 23, 1939, it chose the 45-year-old Crockatt to head the new organization. The former head of the London Stock Exchange, he was seen as “the right sort of chap” for the post despite his scant experience in military intelligence.

MI9’s mission was to help British military personnel escape and evade the enemy. That might mean smuggling maps and miniature compasses to prisoners of war held in Nazi camps or assisting shot-down airmen in enemy territory to evade capture and get back to Britain or Allied-controlled territory. MI9 was a small branch of British intelligence, but in June 1943 Crockatt had the responsibility of making a momentous decision about the fate of 80,000 Allied POWs incarcerated in Italian prison camps. The Allies were gearing up to invade Italy and Crockatt had to decide whether the POWs there should stay put and wait for the arrival of Allied troops or break out and try to make their own way to freedom.

Crockatt chose the former option, stating in an order issued on June 7, 1943, that “officers commanding prison camps will ensure that prisoners of war remain within camp. Authority is granted to all officers commanding to take necessary disciplinary action to prevent individual prisoners of war attempting to rejoin their own units.” Several factors influenced Crockatt’s final decision. First was the physical state of the prisoners, many of whom were believed to be malnourished after years in captivity. Then there was the prospect of tens of thousands of prisoners on the loose, providing easy targets for vengeful Nazis and fascist Italians loyal to Mussolini. Above all, Crockatt believed that the Allies’ advance north through Italy would be swift and British and American troops would quickly liberate the camps. Why risk a mass breakout and jeopardize the lives of so many men?

Lieutenant Colonel Charles “Tony” Simonds of the British A Force received orders to plan the rescue of prisoners of war who had escaped from their prison camps in Italy.

To get word to the POWs of what they should do, Crockatt used a secret code contained within the script of a popular BBC program, *The Radio Padre*, a favorite among the prisoners. But what MI9 didn’t do, remarkably, was inform British prime minister Winston Churchill or his War Cabinet of his decision. From the outset of negotiations with Italy Churchill had made plain his wish to see POWs returned to the Allies once the Armistice came into force. Article 3 of the Italian surrender agreement stipulated that prisoners were to be “immediately turned over to the Allied commander-in-chief and none of these may now or at any

time be evacuated to Germany.” When the Armistice was made public on September 8 the Italian War Ministry kept faith with its obligations and told 80,000 Allied prisoners that they were free to leave. But the majority remained in their camps, where they risked falling under the control of the Germans.

Churchill was aghast when he learned of Crockatt’s order for POWs to stay put, but by then it was too late for many prisoners. Contrary to what Crockatt had anticipated, the Germans had wasted little time in taking over most of the camps and were soon hunting the estimated 30,000 who had defied the stay-put command and taken flight.

Nothing could be done now to liberate the prisoners in the camps, but Churchill demanded a plan to rescue the fugitives. The man chosen to lead the operation was Lieutenant Colonel Charles “Tony” Simonds, who had joined MI9 in 1941 after fighting alongside General Orde Wingate in what is now Ethiopia. Based in Cairo, Simonds was in charge of A Force, which had responsibility to set up escape lines for Allied prisoners across occupied Europe. Summoned to Allied Forces HQ in Algiers on September 23, Simonds received orders to devise a plan to rescue the thousands of escaped Allied prisoners roaming Italy. He had at his disposal personnel from Britain’s 1st Airborne Division, Second Special Air Service Regiment (2SAS), and Special Operations Executive (SOE), as well as the American Office of Strategic Services (OSS). The mission received the code-name *Jonquil*.

In 1940 Bill established a training center at Lochailort, Scotland, where commandos could practice amphibious landings like those the SAS used for the POW rescue mission in Italy.

Simonds established his headquarters at Brindisi, a port on the eastern heel of the Italian boot, and arranged a meeting with officers from 2SAS, billeted 75 miles northwest in the coastal city of Bari. This elite British special forces unit had been formed in North Africa in 1941 by brothers David and Bill Stirling, and while stationed in Cairo Simonds had heard tales of their effectiveness in raiding Axis targets deep inside their territory. David Stirling had been captured in January 1943 but Bill, in command of 2SAS, sent two of his officers, Major Felix Symes and Captain Peter Power, to Brindisi to discuss the rescue operation.

They arrived on the evening of September 26 and for the next three hours Simonds briefed the SAS officers on the nature of the mission. Standing in front of a large map of the east coast of Italy, Simonds explained that he had divided the region into four areas, from Ancona in the north to Ortona in the south, a range of approximately 100 miles. Simonds defined the role of 2SAS in the operation thus: “In each area two parties will go in, one to be dropped by parachute inland, with the object of sending all P. W.s down to the coast, and one party to land by sea to form a beach party to guide, shepherd, and protect the prisoners, and also to supervise their embarkation after having signaled the boats.” There were seven soldiers in each party, and the

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Is Bridgerton's Diversity More Than Just Window Dressing?

Patricia A. Matthew · The Literary Hub

In the sixth episode of Bridgerton's third season, Lady Danbury (Adjoa Andoh) and her brother Lord Marcus Anderson (Daniel Francis) have a fraught and tender confrontation. She has been furious with him from the moment he shows up at one of the series' many gloriously staged balls. At first her anger seems to be because she knows his rakish history and is worried that the attention he is paying to her best friend Lady Violet Bridgerton (Ruth Gemmell) will end in scandal and heartache. But viewers learn that alongside concern for her friend and her general disapproval of sexual licentiousness, her rage is because he thwarted her attempts to escape her father's plan to marry her off to the cruel Lord Danbury.

At first glance (or blush if you're Lady Bridgerton), Lord Anderson seems another piece of eye candy, but this scene is important for a number of reasons. Lady Danbury and her brother are among the older set of the ton (Regency high society), but in front of one another he is a little brother seeking forgiveness from his big sister. All of his charisma is on display not in service of seduction but for the purpose of repair and is a constant in the steamy series: the familial ties that bind. He asks her, and by extension the audience, to see him not as the strapping sexy man but a confused little boy. He is a black baby brother asking his big sister to understand the choice he made. Lord Anderson's vulnerability and tenderness expressed to another Black character stands out in a series where Black men, in power, are depicted as cruel.

Of course, the world is full of Black men with this exact, irresistible combination of strength and vulnerability, but it has been mostly missing from Bridgerton. Regé-Jean Page's Simon Basset in the first season character gets close, but, as his character does in the novels, he disappears after his season, in which his primary purpose was to inspire lust while eating ice cream. Where the Bridgerton men get to struggle with the trials of second sons, and all the white women are afforded a depth of emotion (even terrible Cressida) that makes them sympathetic, Black male characterization has been missing. Will Mondrich (Martins Imhangbe) come close, especially his partnership with his Alice (Emma Naomi), but they have been working their way into the ton.

The characterization of Lady Danbury's cruel husband, whom we meet in Queen Charlotte: A Bridgerton Story, didn't sit right with me. I interpreted it as a way to establish that his cruelty physically distorted him, but the portrayal was shockingly grotesque. Performed by the handsome actor Cyril Nryi, his characterization evoked Julius Soubise, an enslaved man brought to England as a "gift" and depicted by the Printmaker William Austin in the etching "The Duchess of Queensberry Playing at Foils with her Favorite Lap Dog Mungo." It was a relief, then, to meet two Black men in the third season who are kind and depicted as three-dimen-

sional characters and to see their character arcs reach into the fourth.

Along with the introverted Lord Kilmartin (Victor Alli), the last two seasons have given us characters whose interiority is legible to the audience. We see them not as stoic wounded men whom women are encouraged to love despite their roughness and arrogance, but as self-possessed men enough at ease with themselves to be vulnerable with the women they love. In both seasons, these lovely Black men are depicted reveling in the strength of Black women even as viewers see them navigate their way towards romantic happiness.

These depictions, and their performances, add depth to the series' embrace of multicultural, diverse casting. The series' narratives are set by Julia Quinn and concretized by her fans. In an earlier time, before readers fell in love with historical romance novels by Adriana Herrera, Beverly Jenkins, Courtney Milan, and Vanessa Riley, I might have noted that we are stuck in narratives scripted by white women and their imaginations. And, indeed, Quinn's stories probably are more marketable for a television audience. Within that script, however the showrunners seem to be having a multi-cultural ball and enjoying a range of sexual desire and expression. It has made watching the seasons fun and exasperating at once.

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We can see Bridgerton's diversity in a few ways. The consistent image is that while all of the characters in the main families are white, one needn't be white, thin, or heteronormative to be part of that world. The diverse casting of main characters works in different registers. The series has people of color in major and minor roles. Viewers see race and ethnicity, and in some instances, the characters they watch see it too. Anthony Bridgerton (Jonathan Bailey) knows his wife Kathani Sharma (Simone Ashley) is from India (even if the geography of the country is mangled in season). Lady Danbury points to the history of slavery that the series would have us believe has been repaired by the Black ton. With Sophie Baek (Yerin Ha), viewers see a woman of color, but no one in the series seems to notice that she is not white. Benedick's colorblindness has inspired justified humor as he considers that all the debutants, even the Black ones, might be his mystery woman.

The rituals surrounding the release of a new season of Bridgerton or Bridgerton-related stories are familiar by now to fans and cultural critics. For fans, the excitement isn't simply about who will be cast in roles that live in their imagination due to the wild popularity of the source material; there is also curiosity and a deep investment in what new kind of diversity Chris Van Dusen will bring to the Bridgerton Universe. While the Bridgertons are all white, and indeed there is no indication that Quinn's universe includes people of color, they can be found all over the series. The extras are a happy mix of different races, physical abilities, ethnicities, and sizes.

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Pittsburgh's post-steel economy is a success – and a warning for other cities

Christopher Briem, Regional Economist, Center for Social and Urban Research, University of Pittsburgh · The Conversation US

Slow and steady growth in higher education and health care led to economic advantages for Pittsburgh. YT412/iStock via Getty Images Plus

Few regions pose as much of an economic conundrum as Pittsburgh.

Is the city and region – once the center of American steel-making – a paragon of postindustrial transformation, or a left-behind region still struggling to move beyond its industrial past?

I'm an economist at the University of Pittsburgh and author of the new book "Beyond Steel: Pittsburgh and the Economics of Transformation ." In it, I attempt to reconcile the economic paths that have shaped modern Pittsburgh as the city tries to redefine itself.

One core question is not why the steel industry in Pittsburgh collapsed, but why steel production remained so concentrated in the region for so long.

Past researchers foretold with uncanny accuracy the problems the region would face if it did not move away from its monolithic dependence on the steel industry. One prognostication, made by two University of Pittsburgh economists in the 1960s, stands out more than others.

Pittsburgh's rebrand gets a global stage

When, in May 2009, White House Press Secretary Robert Gibbs announced that Pittsburgh would host the G20 Summit of world leaders that fall, the assembled journalists of the White House press corps presumed it was a lighthearted joke before Gibbs jumped into the substance of the day's briefing.

President Barack Obama announced that Pittsburgh would be the site of the 2009 G20 Summit, a choice meant to showcase the city's postindustrial transformation. Scott Olson via Getty Images News

Yet Gibbs was not joking. At the height of the Great Recession between 2007 and 2009, Pittsburgh was purposely chosen because of its history of overcoming past economic trauma and building new prosperity .

It would be a vision of Pittsburgh repeatedly highlighted by foreign media upon their arrival in Pittsburgh that fall for the summit. More than one major publication described Pittsburgh as " no longer hell with the lid off ," a play on a historical description of the city dating to the 1860s.

That idealized story is based on real change in a region that suffered extraordinary structural decline when a century of dependence on heavy industry imploded in the 1970s. Yet it is a story that needs to be tempered by the chronic poverty and lack of development in many former mill towns

of southwestern Pennsylvania , which have not shared in the greater region's redevelopment. Some communities, including Braddock – ironically, where Andrew Carnegie began his steelmaking empire in the 1870s – remain among the poorest in the nation .

Workers and their families value regional amenities, affordability and many other factors that historically had little impact on corporate site selection.

Christopher Briem, Regional Economist, Center for Social and Urban Research, University of Pittsburgh

How Pittsburgh reinvented itself

University of Pittsburgh economists Edgar M. Hoover and Ben Chinitz led a multiyear study of Pittsburgh's regional economy funded by the Ford Foundation , a private foundation that works to advance human welfare, at the beginning of the 1960s. They described the economic study as an "immersion in regional economics." Their four-volume distillation of all aspects of the Pittsburgh economy foretold the decline the region would face due to the shifting economic geography of the steel industry and Pittsburgh's extreme lack of industrial diversification – things local leaders commonly saw as strengths .

Their comprehensive work left little doubt about Pittsburgh's fate if the city stayed its course. But moving away from steel proved far too difficult for regional civic and business leaders, as the region was almost entirely dependent on steel production and related industries. By putting off real economic change, the collapse of the 1980s was even more painful when it finally arrived.

After the steel industry collapsed in the 1980s, Pittsburgh reinvented its economy around health care, education and technology. Michael Mathes/AFP Collection via Getty Images

Hoover and Chinitz's message applied far beyond Pittsburgh. Pittsburgh may have been an extreme case, but they knew that all U. S. regions needed to learn to adapt in the face of accelerating and inexorable change. At the core of their thesis was the idea that many of the geographic linkages that had long bound certain industries to certain regions – like automotive in Michigan and meatpacking in the Midwest – were weakening. Just as the Pacific Northwest no longer relies on the timber industry, or as coal has failed to sustain prosperity in West Virginia, no region can rely on past dominance in any industry to ensure future prosperity.

Among other shifts they projected , Hoover and Chinitz foresaw that future competition between regions would not rest upon the ability to attract and retain specific industries. Instead, the success of regions would rest on their ability to attract and retain workers, something many regions long took for granted

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Celebrating the Legacy of the Office of Strategic Services 82 Years On

Major Nicholas Dockery · HistoryNet

As the United States stood on the brink of World War II, President Franklin D. Roosevelt recognized the urgent need for innovative military strategies to effectively confront the impending global conflict. Observing the unfolding events in Europe, he realized that defeating the Axis powers would require pioneering approaches to warfare. Roosevelt turned to William J. Donovan, a trusted advisor and former informal emissary, to develop a visionary plan for a global intelligence collection agency.

Donovan, a WWI veteran, drafted the “Establishment of Service of Strategic Information,” a detailed document outlining a groundbreaking framework for a centralized intelligence organization to coordinate the entire government and gather essential data for strategic planning. In his plan, Donovan emphasized that “strategy, without reliable information, is helpless. Likewise, information is useless unless intelligently directed toward strategic purposes.”

Impressed by Donovan’s insight, President Roosevelt established the Coordinator of Information (COI)—the nation’s first national intelligence agency. This marked a pivotal moment in US history, as Roosevelt’s foresight and Donovan’s strategic acumen laid the groundwork for creating an entity that would revolutionize how the United States managed conflict during peacetime and war. Operating under the President’s Executive Office, the COI collected and analyzed information crucial to national security.

A year later, Donovan presented a transformative proposal to restructure the COI into an organization that included covert and clandestine operations in addition to intelligence gathering. He envisioned a new hybrid organization that would shift warfighting from traditional military tactics to unconventional approaches using sabotage, espionage, guerrilla warfare, and psychological operations. Believing in Donovan’s strategic expertise, President Roosevelt approved the proposal, thus creating the Office of Strategic Services (OSS) on June 13th, 1942. The OSS would operate under the Joint Chiefs of Staff, a committee of senior military leaders formed during World War II to advise the President and coordinate military efforts.

Under Donovan’s leadership, the OSS bridged the realms of diplomacy, intelligence, and the military. He recruited technology, economics, psychology, and finance experts to provide specialized knowledge to military operations. Donovan firmly believed in a two-pronged strategy: physically attacking the enemy’s military forces and targeting their morale and spirit. The OSS quickly became a hotbed of innovation, employing diverse specialists, including intelligence analysts, linguists, and field operatives.

Inspired by the British Special Operations Executive (SOE), Donovan developed a unique training methodology. He prioritized specialized training for recruits to operate behind enemy lines and carry out sabotage missions. They under-

went rigorous training in organizing and supporting guerrilla and partisan resistance forces. At the core of the OSS were the Strategic Services Operations (SSO), consisting of six units, each with its specialized areas of expertise and responsibilities. Notably, units like the Special Operations (SO) and the Operational Group (OG) eventually led to the formation of the twelve-person Operational Detachment-Alpha, commonly known today as the Green Berets.

During Operation Torch, the Allied invasion of French North Africa, the OSS demonstrated its strategic prowess. OSS members infiltrated Vichy French Northwest African territory, gathering vital information about enemy forces and defenses, directly influencing the invasion’s planning. The OSS also established and maintained robust contacts with local resistance groups and the Free French forces, significantly undermining the Axis stronghold in the region. Further, through unconventional warfare, the OSS successfully disrupted enemy activities and diverted resources, hindering Axis forces from mounting an effective defense against the main invasion.

However, Operation Torch also exposed some of the OSS’s shortcomings. They underestimated the resistance from the Vichy French forces, resulting in two days of intense, unexpected fighting. Additionally, they overestimated the disruptive potential of the French resistance against the Axis forces, leading to strategic missteps. Some intelligence provided by the OSS also proved to be incorrect or unreliable, causing further complications in the operation’s planning and execution. Despite these setbacks, the experiences from Operation Torch provided invaluable lessons for future operations, including Operation Jedburgh.

During Operation Jedburgh, a covert operation involving clandestine activities, the OSS provided personnel, equipment, and training to three-man teams. These teams were airdropped into occupied Europe, primarily focusing on France, to disrupt German military operations, gather intelligence, and support the larger Allied campaign. Consisting of a commander, an executive officer, and a radio operator, they played a pivotal role in leading local resistance movements against the Germans and carrying out acts of sabotage and guerrilla warfare. Notably, one team member always possessed fluency in the local language, ensuring effective communication and coordination with regional allies.

In addition to providing personnel and training, the OSS handled logistics, the deployment of the teams, and the ongoing supply drops. Much like in Operation Torch, the effectiveness of the teams in Operation Jedburgh varied. They successfully disrupted German communications and logistics in some regions, significantly undermining the German response to the Allied invasion. However, German countermeasures, geography, and local conditions made their efforts less effective in other areas. Nevertheless, Operation Jedburgh showcased the potential of unconventional warfare and marked a successful collaboration between the OSS, the SOE, and the Free French.

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Oscar Wilde Bothered and Bewildered Westerners While Touring to Promote Gilbert and Sullivan

Preston Lewis · HistoryNet

Of all the city slickers ever to venture into the 19th century American West, Oscar Wilde towered above the rest, preening like a peacock with his ostentatious wardrobe, his philosophy of art and his knack for spilling printer's ink across the pages of Western newspapers. In the parlance of the cowboy, Wilde exemplified the "swivel dude," a gaudy fellow worthy of a second look or a tip of the hat. The flamboyant poet and playwright not only turned heads with his eccentric outfits, but also left Westerners scratching their noggins over his esoteric lectures on "The Decorative Arts" and "The House Beautiful." For the better part of two months in 1882 Wilde pranced his way across the frontier, a wholly different breed of pioneer.

Arriving in New York City on Jan. 3, 1882, Oscar Fingal O'Flahertie Wills Wilde spent 51 weeks touring the United States and Canada, traveling 50 of those days west of the Mississippi River. Twenty-seven years old when he arrived, he had accomplished little beyond graduating from Magdalen College, Oxford, self-publishing a play and a thin book of poetry, and ingratiating himself into London's high society with his quick, sardonic wit. During college and afterward Wilde evolved into both a disciple and a proponent of aestheticism, a philosophy best summarized as "art for art's sake." Proponents, or aesthetes as they were called, valued form over function. Aestheticism countered the function-intensive machines of the Industrial Revolution and the Victorian belief that literature and art should provide moral and ethical lessons and restraints on society.

While other aesthetes made greater contributions to the philosophical movement, none was more visible than Wilde, largely due to his extravagant dress and a peculiar fixation on sunflowers and lilies as "the most perfect models of design, the most naturally adapted for decoration—the gaudy leonine beauty of the one and the precious loveliness of the other giving to the artist the most entire and perfect joy." Wherever he spoke in America, runs on florist shops depleted the supply of those two flowers, as fans and skeptics alike were eager either to laud or mock Wilde with them.

Masters of the comic opera Gilbert and Sullivan and their producer, Richard D'Oyly Carte, hoped that by sending Wilde to lecture on the principles of aestheticism, they might lay the groundwork for an American tour of their related production, 'Patience.' Wilde came away with material wealth and name recognition.

Among the skeptics, dramatist W. S. Gilbert and composer Arthur Sullivan parodied the aesthetes with a "fleshly poet" named Reginald Bunthorne, the lead character of their 1881 comic opera *Patience*—the follow-up to their hit comic operas *H. M. S. Pinafore* and *The Pirates of Penzance*. On the back of the duo's latest success, their producer, Richard D'Oyly Carte, decided to take *Patience* across the pond

to North America. Doubting that Americans would understand the play's satire, Carte sought an "advance poster" of aestheticism to promote it. Wilde was the natural choice, as Carte was already serving as the poet's booking manager.

Likely massaging Wilde's ego with a suggestion his poetry was also popular in the United States, Carte persuaded the Irishman to assume the mantle of the fictional Englishman Bunthorne for a lecture tour. The clincher was Carte's offer of half the net profits.

What Wilde excelled at most in his young adulthood was self-adoration and self-promotion, often erasing the line between fame and notoriety. When he arrived in New York, the young nation's biggest celebrity was dime novel hero Buffalo Bill. By the time the aesthete returned to Britain, Wilde—if not eclipsing the future Wild West showman as a household name—had certainly drawn more news coverage than William F. Cody. At very least Wilde was the first celebrity who became famous merely for being famous, launching the superficial celebrity culture that permeates American popular culture to this day.

Wilde stood 3 inches over 6 feet. Protruding from his elongated, colorless face was a prominent nose over coarse lips that sheltered greenish-hued teeth, discolored from too many Turkish cigarettes and too few toothbrushes. His thick eyebrows shaded attentive eyes, and a long mop of tawny brown hair brushed against his shoulders. "He looks better in the dark, perhaps" quipped one St. Louis journalist. A portrait of Wilde printed in the competing Leavenworth Times prompted Kansas' Emporia Daily News to observe, "If it is anything like correct, there will be no chance for Oscar to get a wife in this neck of the woods."

What Wilde lacked in looks, he made up for with a voguish wardrobe that ranged from dark formal suits to gaudy shirts and cravats in vibrant purples, greens and yellows. For his first appearance west of the Mississippi he chose a more subdued outfit, his trademark knee britches in black over black silk stockings and patent leather pumps with large silver buckles. Above that he wore a white shirt and white waistcoat topped with a long-tailed black coat and white kid gloves.

His presentations, though, were neither as bright nor as entertaining as his attire. Wilde read his speeches in a monotone voice with a verbal quirk accentuating every fourth syllable. In advance of his February tour date in St. Louis the *Globe-Democrat* reported, "Curiosity to see Oscar Wilde is greater than to hear him." Following his lecture there to an audience of 1,500 a subhead in the paper's coverage pronounced, A Large and Fashionable Audience Bored by His Talk on Art. The reporter, like many other Western newsmen, christened Wilde "the lord of the lah-de-dah." Others just labeled him an "ass-thete."

After St. Louis and side trips to Illinois, Wisconsin and Minnesota, Wilde on March 20 took the transcontinental railroad for talks in Sioux City and Omaha before lecturing

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From ‘Project Hail Mary’ to Artemis II, spaceflight captures audiences when it centers on people because human space travel is hazardous

Scott Solomon, Teaching Professor of BioSciences, Rice University · The Conversation US

The Artemis II crew poses during a ground systems test ahead of launch. NASA/Frank Michaux

The central premise of the blockbuster film “Project Hail Mary” is a long-shot mission with a familiar goal: Save humanity from extinction. While the details of the threat facing humanity are new to this story, moviegoers are used to bingeing on popcorn while watching a heroic quest to save the Earth from certain doom. And like so many popular movies of this genre, from “Armageddon” to “Interstellar,” the hero’s journey involves a seemingly impossible mission into space.

The film’s release is well timed for the new era of space exploration. NASA’s Artemis II mission, scheduled to launch in early April, will send four astronauts around the Moon on a path that will take them deeper into space than any humans have ever traveled.

NASA’s Space Launch System rocket stands ready at the launchpad ahead of the Artemis II launch, planned for early April. Gregg Newton/AFP via Getty Images

The flyby mission is primarily about testing equipment for a lunar landing in 2028. But the broader plan was outlined in detail in March 2026 by NASA officials: to establish a permanent base on the Moon.

NASA is not alone in its lunar ambitions. Private space companies SpaceX and Blue Origin are developing next-generation spacecraft, rovers and drones to facilitate the American Moon base. And other nations, notably China, are working toward their own lunar outposts.

These nations and corporations see the Moon as a stepping stone toward more ambitious goals: a major human migration into deep space, including Mars.

Given the moment, it’s worth reflecting on what those investing billions in human space exploration, whether tax dollars or private funds, are trying to accomplish. As a biologist, I recognize the limitations of humans as space explorers. As I explain in my book, “Becoming Martian: How Living in Space Will Change Our Bodies and Minds,” while biologists have learned a lot about how the conditions of space affect the human body and mind, sending people on longer missions deeper into space will expose people to unknown health risks.

Boldly going

Plans to send people to the Moon and beyond are accelerating. NASA’s new administrator, Jared Isaacman, has argued that beating China to the Moon is a matter of national security, calling the Moon “the ultimate high ground.” He has also promoted the economic benefits of establishing a

space economy that includes mining and manufacturing on the Moon.

NASA’s Artemis program seeks to establish a long-term human presence on the lunar surface. NASA TV

Subcommittees in both the House and Senate have passed bills to codify these initiatives into law – making the goal of creating a permanent base on the Moon official U. S. policy. They appear to have bipartisan support, and votes in both houses of Congress are expected soon.

The United States and China are targeting landing humans on Mars in the 2030s, with the intention of building infrastructure that enables long-term habitation.

In March 2026, NASA also announced that the agency intends to test nuclear propulsion during an uncrewed flight to Mars in 2028. Nuclear-powered rockets have the potential to substantially reduce the time it takes to reach Mars, which would make crewed flight to the red planet more feasible.

Humans or robots?

But why do people need to go to Mars? As with the Moon, the purported motivations for both the U. S. and China establishing a human presence on Mars are scientific, economic and geopolitical. Yet these are distinct objectives that are often conflated.

In terms of science, NASA has had dramatic success with its Mars rovers, including the discovery last year of a potential biosignature that could be the best evidence yet that the planet was once home to microbial life.

Robotic missions also have a lower price tag and a higher acceptable risk margin than human missions. While Isaacman remains publicly committed to the Artemis program and its human spaceflight goals, the agency’s plan also includes a suite of robotic missions to the Moon’s surface it hopes to develop in partnership with companies, universities and international partners.

Likewise, some economic objectives, such as establishing mining and manufacturing facilities, could be accomplished using AI-equipped robots, such as those Tesla is developing. Robots are a long way from being able to accomplish the full range of tasks that a human can do, but prioritizing robotic activities could lower the exposure that people have to the hazards of space.

If having people on the Moon and Mars is indeed necessary to achieve these objectives, let’s be clear about the risks that the people undertaking these missions will be assuming.

Space and the human body

While scientists have learned a lot about how space affects the body during the six decades of human spaceflight, there

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Irrational decision or helpful evolutionary adaptation? A philosopher on the rationality wars behind ‘nudge’ policy

Alejandro Hortal-Sánchez, Visiting Assistant Professor of Philosophy, Wake Forest University; University of North Carolina – Greensboro · The Conversation US

A classic example of a nudge is making the healthy choices easier to grab in a cafeteria. Maskot via Getty Images

Twelve-year-old Jaysen Carr died in July 2025. While he swam in Lake Murray, a reservoir a few miles from Columbia, South Carolina, *Naegleria fowleri* – a rare amoeba found in warm fresh water – entered through his nose, causing a rapidly fatal brain infection .

Each year in the United States, drowning causes roughly 4,500 deaths , while infections from brain-eating amoebas typically number only two or three . Yet the vividness of these rare deaths powerfully shapes how people perceive and respond to risk . After a 2025 amoeba-related death made headlines in Iowa, for example, open-water swimmers began questioning whether lakes were safe , even as health officials emphasized how rare such infections remain.

Is it irrational to avoid swimming in lakes on hot summer days? How rational is it to fear flying ? How many people worry about contaminants in their drinking water yet never think twice about skipping sunscreen, despite skin cancer being the most common, and largely preventable, cancer in the United States?

These reactions raise a deeper question: What does it mean to call a response “rational” or “irrational”? These are the kinds of ideas I explore in my research on behavioral public policy . How do the assumptions scientists make about human rationality shape the tools governments use to improve social welfare?

When mistakes aren’t really mistakes

Behavioral economists, following Daniel Kahneman , emphasize how heuristics – the mental shortcuts or rules of thumb people use to make quick decisions – produce systematic biases or predictable errors in judgment. From this perspective, these biases born from shortcuts lead people to make choices that do not serve their own interests or stated preferences.

Evolutionary psychologists such as Gerd Gigerenzer instead see those same shortcuts as adaptive responses to uncertainty . Rather than errors, they’re efficient strategies shaped by the environments in which human reasoning actually evolved.

These two perspectives are in disagreement about what counts as rational – and why that matters for policy.

How a care team frames the risks of a procedure affects a patient’s choice. Halfpoint Images/Moment via Getty Images

Consider a few familiar examples. Frame the same medical procedure as having a 90% survival rate rather than a 10% mortality rate and patients respond very differently . Set one option as the default – whether in organ donation, retirement savings or privacy settings – and most people stick with it simply because opting out takes effort.

From a behavioral economics perspective, these are clear cases of bias: judgments shaped by framing, whatever feels most vivid, or inertia rather than careful deliberation.

From an evolutionary perspective, however, the picture changes. In complex environments with limited time, information and attention, relying on defaults or whatever feels most vivid or familiar can be an efficient way to decide without becoming overwhelmed. What looks like a mistake when judged against idealized models of rational choice may instead be a sensible response to real-world uncertainty.

This perspective helps explain why small changes in choice environments – nudges such as placing salad bars directly in cafeteria serving lines or listing vegetarian options first on menus – can significantly shift behavior without forcing anyone to choose differently. In other words, nudges work precisely because they align with, not fight against, the shortcuts people already use, making the desired behavior the path of least resistance.

Behavioral economists defend nudges as tools for correcting cognitive biases. Gigerenzer criticizes them as ethically problematic and argues that public policy should emphasize education over subtle choice manipulation.

Should policy correct or educate? This divide, called the “rationality wars ,” reflects a deeper disagreement about human rationality itself .

If human rationality is seen as deeply flawed, nudges appear attractive because they make better decisions easier without demanding reflection.

If, instead, rationality is viewed as adaptive and teachable, policy should focus on strengthening people’s capacity to learn, adapt and decide for themselves.

Rationality isn’t just one thing

From bestselling books such as behavioral economist Dan Ariely’s “Predictably Irrational” to the worldwide expansion of behavioral “nudge” units in government, many contemporary developments suggest that people are poor decision-makers. Struggles with retirement savings, health, weight loss and environmental protection seem to confirm that view.

And yet, as a species, humans have been extraordinarily successful – adapting to diverse environments, building complex societies and accumulating knowledge across gen-

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Every One Still Here

Aea Varfis-van Warmelo · Granta

He is on his way to the psychic who works on Bloomfield Avenue. He's booked an appointment with them on the recommendation of a neighbour, the one who child-minds in her adjacent one-bed flat.

The neighbour sees him one day on the stairs and the way she looks at him, he has to say, How's it going, and she says, Well, you know the way I've never taken a shower my whole life, the thing makes me shake and cry and throw up, and it's difficult, you understand, life-limiting, in fact, to always need access to a bath, to bathe, well, this psychic's after telling me that it's not my fault at all, it's my mother, my mother used to put us in a cold shower as a punishment when we done wrong, not that we even really done any wrong, you understand, she was a headcase and she was horrible and I'm glad that she's dead.

He says, The psychic knew? And the neighbour says: Once it was said, then that second, I mean, that very second, I remembered, I knew it was right. She did, she used to put us in the cold shower and we'd be screaming, and it winter, and she fucking did it, the fucker.

Who's the psychic? he says. And she looks at him, wondering if he is taking the piss. They've never spoken before, except to say: How's things, and: Grand, grand. He sees her on the stairs, scrapping with various children. They're on Bloomfield Avenue, she says. That's them there.

It's a small set-up above a hardware store with brooms and plastic flower baskets set out on the pavement. He presses the buzzer, climbs the narrow carpeted stairs, sits on one of the three office chairs set out as a waiting-room, takes a cupful of plastic water from the dispenser. There's an old smell of incense, and the click of an intermittent automated air freshener, and the pale sound of harp music playing through a Bluetooth speaker and cars passing, spitting old rain up from puddles. There're posters on the walls about healing circles and meditation and sacred sessions, the discreet promise of ayahuasca, of drugs. He's worried about seeing someone he knows, about being embarrassed, but he finds the emptiness distressing, too; here he is, he thinks, the only fucker stupid enough to be here.

The psychic says, What brings you to me?

He says, Aren't you supposed to know?

The psychic says: Everyone, no word of a lie, every single person says that. You've, none of youse, you've no concept of how this works.

They look at each other. What's your name? he says. Ursa, the psychic says.

Is that your real name? he says.

I don't think that's polite, says the psychic. He hears the click of the air-freshener. There's also no good answer. A real name, you mean, did I choose it or did someone choose it for me? Why should you care either way? What difference could it make to you?

I don't know how this works, he says.

No, says the psychic. Fuck me, I can see that much. How does it work? he says, eventually.

It depends. It depends on the person. It depends how open they are, how clear they are on what they want. You, I don't think you're clear at all. You don't—I mean, there's people come in and they've one clear question. Do I marry him? Is she going to live? Even bigger questions, you know, what should I do? It's big and it's vague but it's one thing, it's one query. You, I mean, you don't have one question, you have thousands. You're—the way you are, everything's a question.

Yeah, he says.

That wasn't a question, said the psychic. I wasn't asking you. I can see it. Listen, you can't play Where's Wally if you don't know what Wally looks like. The psychic sighs. But we can try have a look around, see what we see. We might find eventually you go, O my days, there he is. I knew him once. That guy's Wally.

You don't need to dumb it down, he says.

The psychic flicks their eyes to the ceiling. Listen, says the psychic, we're only after meeting. Let's not expect too much. I want you to tell me one thing. I want you to think of—it's not nice, this, but we all feel guilty about something, okay, and we all have some image that makes us wince, that stings, you know, I mean I know there's an image in your head as I'm saying this now. And I want you to share that with me.

He is surprised by the panic he feels, the sharpness in his throat. I don't want to, he wants to say, but he can't. He says, I thought you were going to tell me things, I didn't know I'd have to tell you.

Yeah, says the psychic. I said it, youse all do it, youse come in with no concept of how this works. Look, you were thinking of something there. Just say it. You'll feel better if you do.

And it's true that the word GUILT did bring to him an image. He has a sister, he is thinking.

He looks behind the psychic, at the painted wall.

He has a sister and he hates watching her brush her hair. However she does it, she creates more tats with every stroke. She keeps her hair long, very long, long enough that people make assumptions about her, about its purpose or meaning, and the way she brushes it, she makes it knot and tangle in other places, creates these huge tats of mess, and it's frustrating, infuriating to watch her, to watch it

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Vagus nerve stimulation shows promise as a way to counter Alzheimer's disease- and age-related memory loss

Elizabeth Riley, Lecturer in Psychology, Cornell University · The Conversation US

The vagus nerve, which carries information between the brain and heart, lungs and other organs, might regulate the activity of a tiny brain region called the locus coeruleus. Sebastian Kaulitzki/Science Photo Library via Getty Images

Most people think of Alzheimer's disease as an illness of aging. But in fact, the brain changes that characterize it begin much earlier – sometime around the third decade of life.

In the earliest of these changes, a tangled version of a protein called tau starts building up in a tiny region deep in the brain involved in sleep, attention and alertness, called the locus coeruleus. Tau later spreads to the rest of the brain.

Developing tau tangles doesn't mean a person has Alzheimer's disease – in fact, it happens to nearly everyone to varying degrees. But because these changes start in the locus coeruleus, some brain researchers – myself included – see this area as a canary in the coal mine for developing Alzheimer's disease.

We are exploring whether stopping or slowing down tau tangles in this brain region, or otherwise maintaining its health, may be a way to interrupt how the disease ultimately unfolds and to prevent other aspects of cognitive aging.

Emerging research from my lab and others is investigating the idea that a therapy called vagus nerve stimulation, which is already widely used for other health conditions, could be one way of keeping the locus coeruleus functioning properly.

The locus coeruleus and Alzheimer's disease

The locus coeruleus sits in the brain stem, the lowest part of the brain. Its name, “blue spot,” comes from a pigment called neuromelanin that its cells produce.

The locus coeruleus plays a crucial role in multiple aspects of basic human functioning. It makes virtually all of the brain's norepinephrine, a chemical critical for sleep, alertness, focus, learning and even immune function. And it receives inputs from nerves originating throughout the brain and body – including from the vagus nerve, which carries information to and from the heart, lungs and other organs.

My research explores this brain region's structure, how nerve cells pass messages within it and how it connects with other brain regions. I also investigate how those features change throughout life and affect thinking and memory.

Alzheimer's disease destroys memory and thinking skills, but researchers don't yet understand how or why.

Studies suggest that starting in middle age, nerve cells in the locus coeruleus may get damaged by tau buildup, and that damage may correlate with declines in memory. Tau buildup, cell death and loss of function in the locus coeruleus precedes and predicts Alzheimer's diagnosis and symptoms.

This has led researchers to hypothesize that keeping the locus coeruleus healthy could be a way to protect the rest of the brain, too.

Vagus nerve stimulation and brain health

The vagus nerve carries information between the brain and organs in the chest and abdomen, such as the heart and intestines, helping the brain monitor and regulate many of the body's essential organs. It is responsible for sending rest and digest messages throughout the brain and body, stimulating digestion and promoting cellular repair.

In the 1980s and 1990s, researchers discovered that stimulating the vagus nerve can help ease epilepsy. They also found that doing so often also had other benefits, such as improving mood and thinking.

Today, vagus nerve stimulation is approved by the Food and Drug Administration not just for treating epilepsy, but also for migraine and depression, as well as to aid with stroke rehabilitation.

Vagus nerve stimulation for epilepsy and depression generally involves implanting an electrical stimulator in the left side of a patient's chest, where the vagus nerve passes. Noninvasive devices for treating headaches deliver gentle pulses of electricity to certain places on the neck or ear where the vagus nerve is very close to the surface of the skin.

Even before the discovery of locus coeruleus's link to Alzheimer's disease, researchers hypothesized that vagus nerve stimulation might help mood and thinking in people with the condition. That's because vagus nerve stimulation might work in part by raising brain levels of norepinephrine – and people with Alzheimer's have too little norepinephrine in their brains.

Keeping the pace

Neuroscientists still don't know exactly how or why vagus nerve stimulation might be beneficial for the brain, but one leading theory is that it helps regulate the activity of nerve cells in the locus coeruleus, enabling it to function properly.

Too much locus coeruleus activity could potentially make people too alert, causing them to feel stressed or even panicked. In fact, a hyperactive locus coeruleus fuels some symptoms of post-traumatic stress disorder. Conversely, too little could cause depression or memory problems.

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Cameras have quietly appeared in thousands of US cities – now, their integration with AI is sounding alarms

Jess Reia, Assistant Professor of Data Science, University of Virginia · The Conversation US

A small, black license plate recognition camera is mounted on a light pole in Boulder, Colo. Matthew Jonas/MediaNews Group/Boulder Daily Camera via Getty Images

For decades, cars dictated urban planning in the United States .

Few could have predicted that they would one day also double as nodes for surveillance.

In thousands of towns and cities across the U. S., automatic license plate readers have been installed at major intersections, bridges and highway off-ramps.

These camera-based systems capture the license plate data of passing vehicles, along with images of the vehicle and time stamps. More recently, these systems are using artificial intelligence to create a vast, searchable database that can be integrated with other law enforcement data repositories.

As a scholar of technology policy and data governance , I see the expansion of automatic license plate readers as a source of deep concern. It's happening as government authorities are seeking ways to target immigrant and transgender communities , are already using AI to monitor protests , and are considering deploying AI systems for mass surveillance .

Eyes on the road

Using cameras to track license plates dates to the 1970s, when the U. K. was embroiled in a long-simmering conflict with the Irish Republican Army.

The Met, London's police force, developed a system that used closed-circuit television cameras to monitor and record the license plates of vehicles entering and exiting major roads.

The system and its successors were seen as useful crime fighting tools. Over the next two decades, they expanded to other cities in the U. K. and around the world. In 1998, U. S. Customs and Border Protection implemented this technology . By the 21st century, it had started appearing in cities across the U. S.

There are different ways for a jurisdiction to implement these systems, but local governments usually sign contracts with private companies that provide the hardware and service.

These companies often entice authorities with free trials of surveillance equipment and promises of free access to their data in ways that bypass local oversight laws.

AI thrown into the mix

Recently, AI has been incorporated into these camera systems, significantly increasing their reach .

The vehicle information that's captured is typically stored in the cloud, creating a massive web of data repositories. If a camera collects information from a suspect's car or truck – say, one also listed in the National Crime Information Center – AI can flag it and send an instant alert to local law enforcement.

In fact, that's a selling point of Flock Safety , one of the biggest providers of automatic license plate readers. The company uses infrared cameras to capture images of vehicles. AI then analyzes the data to identify subjects and quickly alert local authorities.

On the surface, automatic license plate readers seem like a logical way to fight crime. More information about the whereabouts of suspects can potentially help law enforcement. And why worry about cameras if you're following the law?

License plate readers can easily be accessed or repurposed beyond their original goals of managing traffic, meting out fines or catching fugitives.

Jess Reia, Assistant Professor of Data Science, University of Virginia

A spokesperson for Flock told The Conversation that their technology has helped reduce crime, including violent crime, in cities that use their cameras, such as San Francisco and Oakland.

But there are few peer-reviewed studies on their effectiveness. Those that exist find little evidence that they've led to reductions in violent crime rates , though they seem to be helpful in solving some crimes , like car thefts.

Furthermore, installation and maintenance are costly.

For example, Johnson City, Tennessee, signed a 10-year, US\$8 million contract with Flock in 2025. Richmond, Virginia, paid over \$1 million to the company between October 2024 and November 2025 and recently extended its contract, despite opposition from some residents.

A Houston resident photographs a Flock license plate reader in his neighborhood in October 2025. AP Photo/David Goldman

Erosion of civil liberties in plain sight

The technology seems to highlight the pitfalls of what scholars call “ technosolutionism ,” the belief that complex issues like crime, poverty and climate change can be solved by technology.

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Potato Gnocchi

Melissa Nolan · Budget Bytes

Gnocchi is truly an art. It can seem intimidating at first, but with the right mindset and a little intuition, this Potato Gnocchi turns into a delicious dish. The actual recipe is just four simple ingredients that result in a breathtakingly delicate yet intricate meal. If you've shied away from making these potato-based dumplings in the past, let me walk you through it. The result is absolutely worth it—homemade soft pillowy gnocchi can not even compare to store-bought.

This potato gnocchi recipe starts with baked potatoes, soft and fluffy inside, the skins removed, gently mixed with salt and egg yolks. Then the flour gets added gradually until the dough feels soft, light, and just a bit tacky, but never sticky. You'll have to use your instincts here to make sure you have the right texture. The fun part is next, where you roll the dough into ropes and cut them into perfect "knuckles" (that's what gnocchi actually means!). Then I suggest you boil them, drain them, and sear those perfect pillows of gnocchi in butter.

Though there are different ways to make these pasta-like dumplings, whether you want to add ricotta, like in our easy ricotta gnocchi, or follow this method with egg yolks, you'll find there are just as many ways to eat them as there are to prepare them. I am keeping it simple here with just a quick pan fry, but you can definitely dress them up with your favorite marinara sauce.

Bake the potatoes instead of boiling. Baking helps prevent the potatoes from absorbing excess water. If you do decide to boil them, start them in cold water and cook them whole and unpeeled to help reduce moisture absorption.

Make sure not to overwork the dough. I only kneaded it for a minute to help it come together and to see if any additional flour was needed.

Let the dough rest for ten minutes. This allows the flour to fully hydrate and the gluten to relax, making the dough easier to roll.

I stuck with traditional potato gnocchi. And added two egg yolks. Yolks provide binding without extra moisture and protein from the whites, which can make the dough tougher and lead to a chewier, less tender texture. I like to save my egg whites and add them to a frittata!

If you are going to sear the gnocchi in butter. Make sure to dry them off as much as possible. You can let them dry on paper towels or on a wire rack. This will help prevent them from sticking in the pan. Make sure to get the pan and butter nice and hot!

If you skip the searing. They can go right from the boiling water into the warmed pasta sauce of your choice.

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When they have cooled enough to handle but are still warm, peel the skin or scoop out the insides of the potatoes and place them in a bowl. I got 2½ cups of cooked potatoes. (You can season, oil, and air-fry the skins for a snack)

Add the remaining flour. Use your hands and continue to work it into the potatoes until they are no longer sticky or wet. Add a dusting of flour if needed. Be careful not to overwork.

Lightly dust your counter with flour and place the dough on the surface. Knead the dough for one minute, incorporating a dusting of flour if it is sticking.

Lightly flour your hands. Gently, but firmly, pinch each piece of gnocchi, then roll it on the back of a fork to create grooves. Continue until all they are all shaped, placing them on a floured tray.

Bring a medium pot of water to a boil. Once at a boil, gently place the gnocchi in the pot. Make sure not to overcrowd, and work in batches if needed. After 2 minutes, they will begin to float. Once they begin to float, they are cooked and should be removed promptly. Avoid overcooking them in the water because they will turn mushy. Using a slotted spoon, remove them and place them on paper towels to drain. Continue cooking until all the gnocchi are done.

Melt 1 Tbsp butter in a medium skillet over medium heat. Once melted and hot (the butter should be almost browning), place half the gnocchi in a single layer in the pan. Cook undisturbed for 3 minutes, until they are crispy and brown. Using tongs, flip, and continue cooking for another 3 minutes. Continue with the remaining tablespoon of butter and gnocchi.

See how we calculate recipe costs here.

* Russet potatoes are best for potato gnocchi because of their low moisture content. You could also use Yukon Gold, but avoid waxy potatoes like red bliss, fingerling potatoes, and new potatoes. Waxy potatoes tend to lead to a heavy, gluey texture.

**There are numerous variables when it comes to the amount of flour you need. (Ex: How much moisture is in the potatoes? How big are the potatoes? How big are the egg yolks? How humid is the kitchen?) You will need to add a little bit of flour at a time to achieve the right texture. The dough should be soft, light, and slightly tacky, but not sticky.

Serving: 1 serving (about 25 pieces) | Calories:

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standard-article(title: [Episode 231: On Dexter Avenue], author: [Nate DiMeo], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([Order The Memory Palace book now, dear listener. On Bookshop.org , on Amazon.com , on Barnes & Noble , or directly from Random House . Or order the audiobook at places like Libro.fm .], [During mid-May, 2025, I'm doing a Midwestern book tour, with stops in Minneapolis, Cincinnati, Indianapolis, and Chicago. Find out more at www.thememorypalace.us/events .], [The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia from PRX. Radiotopia is a collective of independently owned and operated podcasts that's a part of PRX, a not-for-profit public media company. If you'd like to directly support this show, you can make a donation at Radiotopia.fm/donate. I have recently launched a newsletter. You can subscribe to it at thememorypalacepodcast.substack.com .], [You can access the self-produced history of the Sophie Bibb Chapter of the UDC here. The Alabama Encyclopedia site does a nice job with some of this stuff. You might want to check out Caroline Janney's book, Burying the Dead but Not the Past: Ladies' Memorial Associations and the Lost Cause.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 183, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

map: (:), word-count: 304, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Episode 101 (Promise)], author: [The Memory Palace], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia , from PRX, a curated network of extraordinary, story-driven shows.], [SPOILERS BELOW], [I first heard about Hazel Scott while reading Rad American Women from A to Z to my daughter. It's a wonderful book. You should buy it for any kid in your life.], [I read a lot about Hazel, but Karen Chilton's biography, Hazel Scott: A Pioneering Jazz Pianist from Cafe Society to HUAC was essential.], [Starts with Christophe Beck and DeadMono's theme to Charlie Countryman .], [Tezeta (Nostalgia) from Malatu Astatke, from Ethiopiques vol. 4, one of my favorite pieces of music in the world.], [Marian Lapansky plays Camille Saint-Saens "Le Sygne."], [Which fights with Piero Umiliani's Danza Primitiva.], [Warren Ellis rounds it out with his Lale's Theme from his terrific score to Mustang (which you should totally see).], [The Hazel Scott pieces can be found here and here .], [Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 165, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Notes from February 2026], author: [Evan Hahn], source-name: [Evan Hahn], images: (), paragraphs: ([Things I did and saw this February.], [id="things-i-made">Things I made], [I shipped my first feature at Ghost: Inbox Links . When a member enters their email to log in or sign up, we now show a button that takes them straight to their inbox. In addition to shipping a neat feature, I also enjoyed learning about MX records and RFC-compliant email address parsing. The source code for the main logic is here .], [I was surprised to learn that gzip streams encode which operating system did the compression. I built a little tool, "gzpeek", to inspect this metadata (and more).], [The 40th anniversary of the original Legend of Zelda was this month, and I wanted a calendar feed for other game anniversaries, so I made one . Oracle of Ages and Oracle of Seasons just turned 25 yesterday! Speaking of, I wrote a few articles for Zelda Dungeon as usual.], [id="cool-links-from-online">Cool links from online], [An incredible stunt: a game written in HTML and CSS . "No JavaScript or server-side code is used."], [Best description of LLMs I've seen so far: "When you enter text into [ChatGPT], you're asking 'What would a response to this sound like?']", [Seems like it's better for your programming career to be bullish on AI, according to "AI skepticism is a quiet career killer" .], ["Countries are growing uneasy about their dependence on US technology firms" , which the US is trying to stop . We deserve to lose this battle.], ["The lack of European billion-dollar technology companies leads people to forget the technology invented here that instead embraced openness: the web, Linux, Raspberry Pi, Open StreetMap, the Fediverse."], [Someone has decided to pick up a retro video game instead of doom scrolling .], ["This isn't about paranoia. It's about understanding the trade-offs we make when we leave wireless radios enabled on our devices. For some use cases, Bluetooth is essential. For others, it's just convenience. Being aware of what you're exposing is the first step to making

standard-article(title: [From the Vault: A Special Mother's Day Re-Run], author: [The Memory Palace], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia. In Toronto? Chicago? Milwaukee? Minneapolis? Come see a live Memory Palace show . For Mothers' Day, this episode is a re-mixed version of a story originally released as Episode 10 , in 2009. Back with new episodes next time out. The two piano pieces that bookend the piece are by Max Richter from his " 24 Postcards in Full Color " record. The one in the middle is " Maybelle " by Ida. It popped up on shuffle the other day and stunned me. I hadn't heard it in years. It's really lovely.], [Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 108, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Episode 80 (Shore Leave)], author: [The Memory Palace], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([Music* Under the credits is Harlaamstrat 74 off of John Dankworth's Modesty Blaise score.* First up is one of my very favorite recordings of all time: Andromeda from Chris McGregor's Brotherhood of Breath. One of the finest bands ever assembled. * The sailors get grumpy to Sito from Pierre Favre and the European Chamber Ensemble. (The end drum loop comes from that piece too). * The guys run off to save the day to Edgar Meyer and Mark O'Connor doing the Green Groves of Erin.* That turns into, In Threes by Loscil.], [Notes* Some of the details in here originate from a fine piece that appeared in the Saturday Evening Post in May of 1944. You can read it here.* Other solid write ups: From The Book of New York The U. S. C. G. The Fire-fighter's Museum], [Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 143, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

informed decisions about which category your devices fall into.” From “What Your Bluetooth Devices Reveal About You” .], [“I want to break down how [Content Security Policy] actually works and, more importantly, where people screw it up.”], [“The research [...] did not find a single example where popular tools such as Google’s Gemini or Microsoft’s Copilot were leading to a ‘material, verifiable, and substantial’ reduction in planet-heating emissions.”], [First read the term “openwashing”, which describes the process of using the word “open” as marketing. OpenAI and Android are examples of this. See “Acting ethically in an imperfect world” .], [Hope you had a good February.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 437, edited-for-length: true, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Episode 90: A White Horse], author: [Nate DiMeo], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia from PRX. Radiotopia is a collective of independently owned and operated podcasts that’s a part of PRX, a not-for-profit public media company. If you’d like to directly support this show and independent media, you can make a donation at Radiotopia.fm/donate.], [This episode was originally released in 2016 in the days after the shooting at the Pulse nightclub in Orlando. It is re-released every year on the anniversary of the incident.], [A note on notes: We’d much rather you just went into each episode of The Memory Palace cold. And just let the story take you where it well. So, we don’t suggest looking into the show notes first.], [Notes and Reading:], [* Most of the specific history of the White Horse was learned from “Sanctuary: the Inside Story of the Nation’s Second Oldest Gay Bar” by David Olson, reprinted in its entirety on the White Horse’s website .], [* “Gayola: Police Professionalization and the Politics of San Francisco’s Gay Bars, 1950-1968,” by Christopher Agee.], [* June Thomas’ series on the past, present, and future of the gay bar from Slate a few years back.], [* Various articles written on the occasion of the White Horse’s 80th anniversary, including this one from SFGATE. Com], [* Michael Bronski’s A Queer History of the United States .], [* Radically Gay , a collection of Harry Hay’s writing.], [* Incidentally, I watched this interview with Harry Hay from 1996 about gay life in SF in the 30’s multiple times because it’s amazing.], [* We start with Water in Your Hands by Tommy Guerrero.], [* Hit Anne Muller’s Walzer fur Robert a couple of times.], [* Gaussian Curve does Talk to the Church .], [* We get a loop of Updraught from Zoe Keating.], [* We finish on Transient Life in Twilight by James Blackshaw],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 309, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [Jai Courtney’s Underrated Shark Horror Movie Out on Hulu Today], author: [Maggie Dela Paz], source-name: [ComingSoon.net], images: (), paragraphs: ([(Photo Credit: IFC)], [Independent Film Company’s acclaimed creature feature starring Suicide Squad’s Jai Courtney has finally found a new streaming home, nearly a year after it had its world premiere at the 2025 Cannes Film Festival’s Directors’ Fortnight section. As of today, Courtney’s survival horror movie Dangerous Animals is now officially streaming on Hulu.], [In Dangerous Animals, Courtney plays the role of a serial killer who uses

standard-article(title: [Two Small Sculptures (The Met Residency Episode 8)], author: [The Memory Palace], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([Nate DiMeo was the Metropolitan Museum of Art’s Artist in Residence for 2016/2017. He produced 8 episodes inspired by the collection and by the museum itself. This is the eighth episode of that residency.], [This residency is made possible by the Metropolitan Museum of Art’s Chester Dale Fund.], [This episode is written and produced and stuff by Nate DiMeo with engineering assistance from Elizabeth Aubert. Its Executive Producer is Limor Tomer, General Manager Live Arts, The Metropolitan Museum of Art.], [Hiawatha , Edmonia Lewis, 1868.], [Minnehaha , Edmonia Lewis, 1868.], [Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 108, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

standard-article(title: [episode 76: Mary Walker Would Wear what she Wanted], author: [Nate DiMeo], source-name: [The Memory Palace], images: (), paragraphs: ([This episode was originally released in 2015.], [Proceeds from this episode are being donated to the Transgender Law Center .], [*Under the credits is Harlaamstrat 74 off of John Dankworth’s Modesty Blaise score.], [*The piece opens with Rainfall , by David Darling and Michael Jones.], [*Her brief love story is scored by Nathan Johnson’s Penelope’s Theme from his score to The Brothers Bloom .], [*When she lands her first gig, we start Garde a Vue, and roll into Le Roi

sharks to kill his victims. The cast also included Hassie Harrison, Josh Heuston, Rob Carlton, Ella Newton, James Munn, Michael Goldman, Jon Quested, Liam Greinke, and more. Since its debut, the movie has received a Certified Fresh rating of 87% on Rotten Tomatoes , based on 181 reviews.], [“When Zephyr, a rebellious surfer, is abducted by a shark-obsessed serial killer and held captive on his boat, she must figure out how to escape before he carries out a ritualistic feeding to the sharks below,” reads the official synopsis.], [The 2025 film was directed by Sean Byrne from a screenplay written by Nick Lepard. The film was executive produced by Fred Berger, Michael Glassman, Mehrdod Heydari, Marlaina Mah, Jacob Yakob, and Joseph Yakob. Producers were Chris Ferguson, Brian Kavanaugh-Jones, Mickey Liddell, Troy Lum, Andrew Mason, and Pete Shilaimon.], [Besides Dangerous Animals, Courtney was also seen in last year’s Australian fantasy comedy The Fox. He most recently starred in Netflix’s latest sci-fi action thriller War Machine with Alan Ritchson and Dennis Quaid. He is currently attached to star in the upcoming Yellowstone spin-off Dutton Ranch, which will be led by returning stars Kelly Reilly and Cole Hauser.], [The post Jai Courtney’s Underrated Shark Horror Movie Out on Hulu Today appeared first on ComingSoon.net - Movie Trailers, TV & Streaming News, and More .],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 299, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

de coeur , from Chantal Martineau.], [* The vibraphone piece is “Opening” by Nathaniel Bartlett.], [* The recurring violin piece is called Geometria del Universo by the one-named Colleen.], [* It ends on Romain’s First Love , again by Georges Delarue, from his fantastic score to Promise at Dawn.], [* I read a lot about Mary, but by far the most useful and most thorough works I came upon were: Sharon M. Harris’ Dr. Mary Walker: An American Radical and A Woman of Honor: Dr. Mary E. Walker and the Civil War, in which author Mercedes Graf does a great job walking the reader through Walker’s unpublished memoir.], [The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia , a collective of independently owned and operated podcasts.],), insert-map: (:), word-count: 208, edited-for-length: false, debug-mode: false,)

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Episode 222: Ferminia Sarras

Nate DiMeo · *The Memory Palace*

Pre-order The Memory Palace book now, dear listener. On Bookshop.org , on Amazon.com , on Barnes & Noble , or directly from Random House .

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Notes The definitive source on Ferminia Sarras (as far as definitive can be in her case) A Mine of Her Own: Women Prospectors in the American West, 1850-1950 by Sally Zanjani.

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ANALYSIS

IN BRIEF

The Memory Palace, The Memory Palace: The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia , a collective of independently owned and operated podcasts.

Music

We start off with a touch of Hills in the Rain , by Simon Rackham.

Go to a bit of Narkopop 1 by Gas.

Then gaze in wonder to Grofe's Grand Canyon Suite: Sunrise , as performed by the Cincinatti Pops Orchestra

We listen to two versions of Trying Something Again, Again by our friends in Lullatone.

And go out on Jaybird , by Charlie Parr

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The Memory Palace, The Memory Palace: The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia.

Music

Blink from Hiroshi Yoshimura

Which comes in and out of Bjolukor Tonlisterakoli Reykjanesbaejar's version of Sigur Ros' Hoppipolla.

Love Token by Elena Kats-Chernin, performed by Tamara Anna Cislowska

And Joanna Brouk playing Maggi's Flute - Lifting Off

Notes

There's

a ton out there about the sixty starlings, the most comprehensive comes

from Stephen Marche's book, How Shakespeare Changed Everything.

I also found Kim Todd's [Tinkering with Eden,](<http://%22Tinkering%20With%20Eden:%20A%20Natural%20History%20of%20Exotic%20Species%20in%20America>) particularly useful.

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The Memory Palace, The Memory Palace: This piece was originally released a few days after the shooting deaths of 49 people at the Pulse Nightclub in Orlando, Florida. It is re-released here on the second anniversary of the event.

If you are so moved, please donate to any of these charities:

Equality Florida .

Human Rights Campaign.

Everytown for Gun Safety .

Trans Lifeline

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The Memory Palace, The Memory Palace: If you enjoy this story, do tell someone about The Memory Palace.

Thanks.

Nate

Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices

The Memory Palace, The Memory Palace: If you enjoy this story, do tell someone about The Memory Palace.

Thanks.

Nate

Learn about your ad choices: dovetail.prx.org/ad-choices

Evan Hahn, Evan Hahn: I wrote a web app to choose a random programming language .

It's very simple; I hesitate to even call it an "app"! The interesting part was scraping all the languages on Rosetta Code , and even that wasn't very interesting. But I hope you like it!

I learned about a language called Arturo this way, and wrote a short story about that experience .

Nate DiMeo, The Memory Palace: The Memory Palace is a proud member of Radiotopia from PRX.

Music

~~What a beautiful day. The sun is shining, the birds are singing, and the flowers are blooming. It's a perfect day to be outside. I'm going to go for a walk in the park. I'll see you there.~~
Dave Pajo/Aerial M does Plastic Energy Man.
In this song, the artist describes how he feels when he's walking around Fresh Pond, across the street from the hotel, though it can be enjoyed anywhere.
Patricia Rossborough played in a Wild Rose
...the first section of the song (Aldo's tragic tale about the platform for a Wild Rose) is not at

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